

Model Council Synthesis: *The Artillery State*

Council convened: Claude Fable 5, Claude Opus 5, GPT 5.6 Sol, Gemini 3.1 Pro, Kimi K3, GLM 5.2 — each independently assessing Roderick B Jones's book-in-progress *The Artillery State: Cannon, Code, and the Return of the Consolidator* as expert historians and public intellectuals. August 2026.

Where Models Agree

Finding	Claude Fable 5	Claude Opus 5	GPT 5.6 Sol	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Kimi K3	GLM 5.2	Evidence
Chronology inversion at the book's hinge: the permanent taille (Orléans, 1439) and compagnies d'ordonnance (1445) precede the Bureau train's decisive employment (1449–53). Finance enabled artillery, not vice versa — artillery should be recast as ratchet/lock-in mechanism, not motor	✓	✓			✓	✓	Anne Curry's Lancastrian Normandy audit; taille des lances, 1439 ; Rogers dates the artillery revolution to the 1420s–30s (De Re Militari)
Formigny is weak evidence; Castillon is the clean case: the two culverins at Formigny were captured by English archers and Richemont's cavalry decided the day; only Castillon shows a prepared artillery park decisively destroying a field army	✓	✓	✓		✓		Britannica, Battle of Castillon
Parrott's <i>The Business of War</i> is the most dangerous unmet counter: state monopoly of force was a ~1760–1960 anomaly; contractor incorporation may be the stable equilibrium, and 2025–26 contractor evidence (Palantir, SpaceX, Anduril) shows devolution occurring concurrently with consolidation	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	H-Net review of Parrott ; Cambridge blog
Bratton's <i>The Stack</i> must be confronted directly: the book borrows his noun without engaging his rival prediction that sovereignty migrates to the stack rather than the state reabsorbing it	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	MIT Press, <i>The Stack</i> ; Bratton's Feb 2026 "Hemispherical Stacks" (MIT Press Reader)

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The counter-cases need recasting: the Swiss (no stack, yet destroyed Burgundy three times in ~12 months) must be resolved explicitly — battlefield victory without the stack does not produce territorial consolidation; and Henry VII consolidated without artillery (chamber finance, bonds, Council Learned) so the book's namesake is an alternative pathway, not a confirmatory case	✓	✓	✓		✓	✓	<u>Tooze on Burgundy's abortive state-building</u> ; <u>Gunn on Henry VII's new men</u>
The methodology is best-in-class but the falsification apparatus needs teeth: dated disconfirmation thresholds (not just directional predictions), genuinely external hostile readers (the current steelmanning is endogenous — the same author/AI writes the critiques), and filled cells in the 2×2 (stack-without-consolidation; consolidation-without-stack)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	All six reports independently praised the brief→sources→memo→critiques→draft pipeline and the firewalled workshop, and all six flagged the same falsifiability gap

All six also read the 2025–26 fiscal-industrial record as net supportive of the thesis: escalating US chip controls including the VEU revocation for TSMC/Samsung/SK Hynix ([Reuters](#)), EU SAFE common defence borrowing, and Russia's real-time failure to make its taille permanent ([Fortune](#)).

Where Models Disagree

Topic	Claude Fable 5	Claude Opus 5	GPT 5.6 Sol	Gemini 3.1 Pro	Kimi K3	GLM 5.2	Why They Differ
US trajectory	Undetermined condominium; "undermighty kingship" may describe the US better than Ch. 12 admits	Venal/tax-farming state — "the Crown joining the syndicate"; proposes a chartered-company (VOC/EIC) third outcome	Contractual/oligarchic settlement; sovereignty defined by who holds revocation rights over access	Textbook consolidation: chokepoint moves (VEU revocation, MATCH Act) are the thesis working as predicted	US has the coercive-technological layer but not the fiscal-legal bargain — a Tudor mismatch	Genuinely ambiguous: Palantir's \$10bn Army contract and the X Directive read equally as state capture of platforms or platform capture of the state	Different weighting of the same events — Gemini scores capability moves as consolidation; Opus 5 and GPT 5.6 Sol ask who profits and who can revoke, and find the state weaker than it looks

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Ukraine and the drone counter-evidence	The present may be a trace italienne (defense-dominance) moment, not a cannon moment — which would gut the "decisive force" half of the mechanism	Layered claim: cheap contact layer atop expensive sensing/compute; "stack-renting" is a viable sovereignty strategy	Cheap force is "denial economics" — it preserves plurality even where costly stacks dominate power projection	Largely supportive: Ukraine restricting unauthorized Starlink terminals shows stack-dependence	The "layer problem": the capital-intensity gradient is non-monotonic; the thesis survives only by specifying which layer carries decisiveness	Drones are the longbow, not the cannon — tactically disruptive, but Ukraine's battlefield success rests entirely on Western stack layers it cannot produce	Different historical analogies for the same battlefield data — longbow (dispersal absorbed), trace italienne (defense-dominance era), or layered gradient — each implies a different fate for the thesis
EU verdict	(Not a primary focus)	Decisive test unmet: SAFE is loans, not a taille — the Tudor moment requires a permanent own resource without unanimity	The EU may strengthen precisely by remaining differentiated — networked consolidation; Zielonka vindicated	Favorable: defence fiscalisation points the thesis's way	SAFE is "the most Tudor-looking event in postwar European history"; date the bet against Zielonka (renewal by 2030)	The most genuinely uncertain case — the political form has lagged the technical need for thirty years; resist scoring it as consolidating	Disagreement over what counts as a taille: Kimi K3 weights the precedent of common borrowing; Opus 5 and GLM 5.2 weight the missing permanent fiscal capacity
Overall verdict	Split the wager into independently scored sub-wagers (fiscal half winning; subordination half not)	Most revisionist: replace the thesis with "Tudor capacity without the Tudor bargain — consolidation without representation"	Rename the mechanism "bottleneck sovereignty" and the outcome "archipelagic consolidation"	Most positive: "thoroughly validated," methodology the "gold standard"	Refine into the "syndicated stack" — subscribers, Hanse-like alliances, renter city-states	More supported than not; the remaining work is conceptual sharpening (stack divisibility, a falsifiability horizon), not more research	Different tolerance for the binary consolidation-vs-dispersal frame: Gemini accepts it; the other five each replace it with a hybrid form and differ mainly on which hybrid

Unique Discoveries

Model	Unique Finding	Why It Matters
Claude Opus 5	The H200 episode is a natural experiment run in both directions inside a single transaction: Beijing subordinated its firms (barred purchases); Washington instead took a 15% revenue cut — the Crown joining the syndicate rather than taxing it	Converts a news item into the book's cleanest paired test of which polity is actually consolidating
Claude Opus 5	The second causal link is severed in the present: the modern stack is financed by private capital markets and Gulf rents, not taxation — so no representation bargain is being struck	If finance doesn't run through the fisc, the Tudor settlement analogy fails at its load-bearing joint; the chartered-company outcome follows

Model	Unique Finding	Why It Matters
Kimi K3	The "syndicated stack": Ukraine as subscriber, NATO as Hanse, Gulf states as renter city-states — plus Spruyt's capital-rich non-consolidators (Hanse, Venice, Dutch) as the omitted comparanda	Supplies the missing vocabulary for polities that access decisive capability without owning it — the case the binary frame cannot describe
Claude Fable 5	Bobbitt's <i>The Shield of Achilles</i> is the missing closest precursor (epochal war → constitutional form), and Scheidel/Hoffman endogeneity: consolidation may kill the innovation that produces the stack	Positions the book in its true lineage and identifies a self-undermining dynamic the coda must address
GPT 5.6 Sol	A control-rights metric — sovereignty measured by who can revoke access (the Starlink shutdown-order investigation as the template) — and nuclear weapons as a scope condition that interrupts interstate selection, not an exclusion	Gives Appendix C an operational indicator, and closes the biggest scope-condition hole in the 15th→21st century transfer
Gemini 3.1 Pro	The modern stack answers Scott's <i>Seeing Like a State</i> objection computationally: planetary computation can absorb metis rather than destroy it	Neutralizes the strongest classical critique of legibility-driven consolidation
GLM 5.2	Bratton's own February 2026 "Hemispherical Stacks" (US, China, India, EU stacks) converges on the book's bloc-settlement prediction from the opposite direction — and stack divisibility (rentable layers vs. the physically indivisible 15th-century train) is the pivotal undertheorized disanalogy (MIT Press Reader)	Independent confirmation of the prediction and the sharpest statement of the condition under which the mechanism transfers at all

Comprehensive Analysis

The council's most striking result is that six models, researching independently, converged on the same correction to the book's engine room — and that the correction strengthens the book rather than sinking it. Four of six (Claude Fable 5, Claude Opus 5, Kimi K3, GLM 5.2) independently established that the fiscal and institutional machinery of French consolidation — the permanent *taille* authorized at Orléans in 1439 and the *compagnies d'ordonnance* of 1445 — predates the Bureau brothers' decisive artillery employment of 1449–53. Anne Curry's audit of Lancastrian Normandy and Clifford Rogers's dating of the artillery revolution to the 1420s–30s both cut the same way: finance built the guns, and only then did the guns make the finance irreversible. The council's unanimous prescription is to recast artillery from motor to ratchet — the mechanism of irreversibility that made the 1439 fiscal settlement permanent by delivering visible, wall-breaking returns. This is a friendly amendment with teeth: it requires rewriting the causal spine of Chapters 6 and 10, retitling or reframing "1450: The Year the Walls Fell," and demoting Formigny (where the two culverins were captured and cavalry decided the day) in favor of Castillon as the sole clean demonstration. Convergence of this specificity, reached from different sources, is the strongest reliability signal the council format can produce.

The second unanimous finding is that David Parrott's *The Business of War* is the book's most dangerous unengaged counter. If wholly state-administered force was a two-century anomaly rather than the terminus of state formation, then the *compagnies d'ordonnance* are not the seed of modernity but an experiment repeatedly unwound by contractor warfare — and the 2025–26 record shows devolution (Palantir's consolidated Army contract, SpaceX's sweep of Golden Dome missions) occurring simultaneously with consolidation. Every model insisted the book must explain why the modern stack will not be devolved the way the early modern one was, and several supplied the answer the book should argue rather than assume: the question is not ownership but control rights. GPT 5.6 Sol's revocation metric — sovereignty belongs to whoever can shut off access — turns Parrott from a refutation into a research design, and GLM 5.2's observation that Washington is deliberately making the stack less rentable (denying ASML servicing, not merely sales) shows policy actively restoring the indivisibility on which the 15th-century mechanism depended.

Where the models genuinely disagree, the divergence is diagnostic rather than noisy. On the United States, the same facts yield four readings: Gemini 3.1 Pro scores the chokepoint campaign as textbook consolidation; Claude Opus 5 reads the H200 revenue-sharing arrangement as venality — the Crown joining the syndicate it should be taxing; GPT 5.6 Sol sees a contractual-oligarchic settlement; Claude Fable 5 suspects "undermighty

kingship" describes Washington better than the book's own Chapter 12. The disagreement traces to a question the book has not yet forced: is consolidation measured by what the state can do to firms, or by what it extracts from them and who can revoke whom? Beijing barred its champions from buying the H200; Washington took a cut of the sale. Opus 5's framing of this as a paired natural experiment inside a single transaction is the single most usable analytical device any council member produced, and the book should adopt it.

On Ukraine, the council split three ways on which historical analogy governs — longbow (GLM 5.2: dispersal that gets absorbed), trace italienne (Fable 5: a defense-dominance era in which nobody's force is decisive, which would gut half the mechanism), or Kimi K3's non-monotonic capital-intensity gradient (cheap contact layer, expensive sensing and compute). These are not reconcilable by evidence currently available, which is precisely why the coda should present them as named, dated rival readings. The honest synthesis, endorsed in substance by Opus 5, GLM 5.2, and Kimi K3: the battlefield layer is cheaply contestable, but Ukraine's four-million-drone campaign runs entirely on Western compute, satellite, munitions, and finance it cannot produce — the stack's expensive layers are carrying the decisiveness, and Ukraine is best described not as a counter-example but as Kimi K3's "subscriber" to a syndicated stack. Russia, meanwhile, is the thesis's strongest live corroboration and should be promoted accordingly: a polity with coercion and battlefield weaponry that is visibly failing to make its *taille* permanent, draining its National Wealth Fund against structural war-cost overshoot ([Fortune](#)).

The EU disagreement is the most productive in the set because it is already a dated bet. Kimi K3 calls SAFE "the most Tudor-looking event in postwar European history" and proposes scoring it against Zielonka by 2030; Claude Opus 5 replies that SAFE is loans, not a *taille* — the Tudor moment requires a permanent own resource enacted without unanimity; GPT 5.6 Sol holds open the possibility that the EU strengthens precisely by remaining differentiated, vindicating Zielonka. This three-way split maps exactly onto the book's needed falsification apparatus: the disagreement is resolvable by 2030 on observable indicators (SAFE renewal, a permanent defence own-resource, qualified-majority fiscal instruments), and Appendix C should encode it as such.

Underneath the disagreements lies a deeper consensus the book must metabolize: five of six models independently rejected the binary consolidation-versus-dispersal frame and replaced it with a hybrid settlement — Opus 5's chartered company, GPT 5.6 Sol's archipelagic consolidation under bottleneck sovereignty, Kimi K3's syndicated stack, Fable 5's condominium, GLM 5.2's live Bratton-versus-Jones contest over whether the state absorbs the stack or the reverse. When five differently-trained models refuse the same dichotomy, the dichotomy is the problem. The book's Tudor settlement already gestures at a negotiated hybrid; the revision is to make the hybrid the explicit predicted outcome and to specify, per bloc, which side of the absorption contest the evidence favors. GLM 5.2's discovery that Bratton himself now forecasts "Hemispherical Stacks" gives the book a remarkable gift: its chief theoretical rival has converged on its bloc-level prediction, leaving only the directionality of sovereignty in dispute — a dispute the 2025–26 evidence can actually adjudicate.

Recommendation. The council's verdict is that this is a serious, publishable, and unusually falsifiable project whose thesis survives review but whose causal architecture needs one major and several minor renovations. The major renovation: invert the hinge — finance first, artillery as ratchet — and let Castillon carry the demonstration alone. The minor ones, in priority order: engage Parrott and Bratton by name as the two structural rivals, with control-rights and stack-divisibility as the adjudicating criteria; recast Henry VII as an alternative fiscal-legal pathway and move the English artillery comparandum to Henry VIII; resolve the Swiss explicitly (battlefield victory without the stack never produced territorial consolidation, and the consolidators priced Swiss force into their procurement within a generation); split the wager into independently scored sub-wagers with dated thresholds and 2026 baselines, adopting Opus 5's indicator table and GPT 5.6 Sol's revocation metric; and commission genuinely external hostile readers, since the current critique apparatus — rigorous as it is — is endogenous. The models' unanimity on method (best-in-class) and their divergence on outcome (four distinct hybrid futures) together define the book's opportunity: it has built

the only apparatus in the field disciplined enough to score that disagreement in public, in real time. That, more than any single historical claim, is what will make it endure.